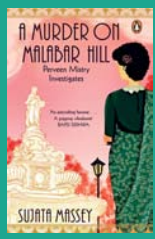
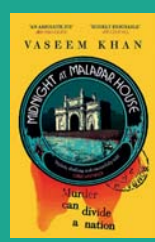
BOMBAY WHODUNITS

Mumbai-set murder mysteries



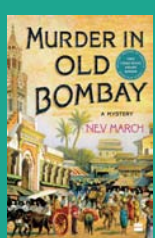


In the Perveen Mistry series, a young woman lawyer-turned-detective investigates mysterious deaths in colonial Bombay. **Sujata Massey**'s sleuth is loosely modelled on Cornelia Sorabji, the country's first female advocate. Mistry has already appeared in three novels: *A Murder on Malabar Hill*, *The Satapur Moonstone* and *The Bombay Prince.*





UK-based writer **Vaseem Khan** has two ongoing series. The Baby Ganesh Agency novels follow former cop Ashwin Chopra in modern Mumbai, and the Malabar House books revolve around Persis Wadia, India's first woman police detective.





Set in colonial India, **Nev March**'s debut novel, *Murder in Old Bombay,* is another historical mystery that follows the investigation into the deaths of two sisters-in-law. Captain Jim Agnihotri, an Anglo-Indian private detective, freshly awash in Sherlock Holmes stories, leads the probe.

Hanky Panky in the Garden City

Though there is a murder at the heart of Harini Nagendra's book, its true subject is Old Bangalore



Beautiful, brilliant and newly-wed Kaveri is the primary sleuth in this murder mystery set in 1920s Bangalore. Her husband, the equally brilliant Dr Ramu Murthy, is her coffee-swilling sleuthing partner.

Early in the tale, our heroine attends a posh dinner at the Century Club. There she sees Manju, the cowherd who delivers milk to her home, moonlighting as a waiter. His little brother Venu has complained to her of being beaten. So, like any right-thinking young Indian woman might do, Kaveri leaps up in mid-dinner to chase down the cowherdly-waiter. She plans to confront him with his misdeeds but many complications arise and she's forced to return to her seat. Just after dessert is served, however, there's a scream from the kitchens. A corpse is found in the Club's backyard. And the cowherd has vanished.

While the murder plot grinds on with the assistance of dastardly pimps and *apsara*-standard prostitutes, the true subject of the book is Old Bangalore. There are charming vignettes of a vanished way of life and a once-beautiful city. But hot tea served in "steel glasses", Indians who "blanch" in shock and a city called Chennai appearing on page 269 strain one's appreciation. The sleuthing couple are shown to be unusually progressive in matters of caste and gender relations but we never know who clears the garbage or read any mention of bathrooms.

> In **HARINI NAGENDRA'S** book, there are charming vignettes of a vanished way of life and a once-beautiful city

The Brits are still in power, of course, whining about the weather and snarling at the "natives". The effort to show Indians as being morally and culturally superior in every possible way borders on reverse-prejudice. If the prologue is to be believed, however, this is only the first of a series. Perhaps the sequels will be smoother? ■

- Manjula Padmanabhan



THE BANGALORE DETECTIVES CLUB
by Harini Nagendra
HACHETTE INDIA
₹499; 287 pages